



GETTY IMAGES

redevelopments alone will add 15,000 flats. The Delhi Development Authority's projects, as well as the luxury towers of private builders are all contributing to the dust load legally.

"We have 1,800 officials ensuring compliance at sites," says Delhi environment minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa. "We check for water sprinklers, covered transport of construction material, anti-smog guns for large sites, and portal registration." Not rules, but enforcement is the problem. "Constant construction is allowed with weak monitoring," says environmentalist Ravi Agarwal of the non-profit Toxics Link. According to the Delhi government, the city produces 6,000 tonnes of construction waste a day but processes only 5,000 tonnes, leaving a daily surplus of 1,000 tonnes.

Delhi has just 52 mechanical sweepers to clean main roads. Inside colonies, manual sweeping stirs dust back up. The city produces 11,332 tonnes of waste a day, but processes only 8,213 tonnes. The rest goes to landfill skyscrapers—Ghazipur (67 metres), Bhalswa (62 m), Okhla (30 m)—which burn garbage and emit methane and soot.

As a deterrent, developers should be given "Dust Control Bonds" where they pay large sums before construction commences, forfeitable if environmental standards are breached. For city waste, Delhi must shift from centralised dumping to ward-level waste processing, treating wet waste at the source. The government should also enforce Extended Producer Responsibility so that companies fund the collection and recycling of the packaging waste they generate.

CONSTRUCTION

FAILURE
DELHI GENERATES **6,000 TONNES OF CONSTRUCTION WASTE DAILY**, BUT CAN PROCESS ONLY 5,000 TONNES, LEAVING A DAILY SURPLUS OF 1,000 TONNES

SOLUTION
GIVE DEVELOPERS "DUST CONTROL BONDS" WHERE THEY **PAY LARGE SUMS BEFORE CONSTRUCTION COMMENCES**, WHICH IS LIABLE TO BE FORFEITED IF ENVIRONMENTAL STANDARDS ARE BREACHED

Stubble Trouble

Even though the government claimed farm fires had come down to 27,720 this year from 54,727 in 2023, it did not show up in Delhi's air. One reason was the timing and detection. A 2022 study by Ashoka University noted that NASA's satellites spot fires from 10.30 am to 2.30 pm, but many farmers burn stubble after dark, to evade detection. They estimate under-reporting by at least a fourth. ISRO findings corroborates farmers burning stubble later in the day. By shifting peak burning times to 5 pm, it says, standard polar satellites (MODIS/VIIRS) missed them. Geostationary data confirms that the vast majority of burning now occurs post-3 pm.

This when Punjab and Haryana have received over 200,000 residue management machines under central subsidies. But narrow sowing windows, labour shortages, diesel-powered machinery, poor management and low accountability persist. Also, as Anumita Roychowdhury, executive director, CSE, points out, crop burning may be a drop in the ocean as far as Delhi's air is concerned. "Delhi-NCR cannot hide behind this smokescreen any more," she says.